

Cactus

You wouldn't want to touch a cactus by mistake. These desert plants are lined with neat rows of sharp spines. The prickly protection stops thirsty animals from getting at the water stored in their sponge-like stem. The spines are actually special leaves. Big, flat leaves would lose lots of water in the hot sun. A crinkled surface helps cacti to stay cool by creating shade.

Deserts in Mexico and the USA have the largest species of cactus in the world, the saguaro (sag-wah-roh). Lots of animals visit it. Bats come to feed at its flowers at night, and woodpeckers peck nest holes in it. When the woodpeckers move out, tiny elf owls move in.



A saguaro cactus can reach 15 m (49 ft) tall and weigh as much as a small car.

